

THREE

THE EVERLASTING GOD¹

I am the Lord, that maketh all things.²

Some religious thinkers try to defend the moral character of God by slurring over his responsibility as everlasting and omnipresent creator. The burden of the Biblical account would seem to be that it is just the everlasting and omnipresent creator who is, and should be expected to be, responsible. The questions of Job remain questions; but they are swallowed up by the counter-questionings of God.

And God said unto Moses, I AM THAT I AM.³

And even to old age I am he, and even to hoar hairs
will I carry you: I have made, and I will bear; yea, I
will carry, and will deliver.⁴

Of old hast thou laid the foundation of the earth;
And the heavens are the work of thy hands.
They shall perish, but thou shalt endure:
Yea, all of them shall wax old like a garment;
As a vesture shalt thou change them, and they shall
be changed:
But thou art the same,
And thy years shall have no end.⁵

I am the first, I also am the last. Yea, mine hand hath
laid the foundation of the earth, and my right hand
hath spread out the heavens.⁶

¹Isa. 40: 28.

²Isa. 44: 24.

³Exod. 3: 14.

⁴Isa. 46: 4.

⁵Ps. 102: 25-27.

⁶Isa. 48: 12-13.

By the word of the Lord were the heavens made;
And all the host of them by the breath of his mouth.¹

The heavens are thine, the earth also is thine:
The world and the fulness thereof, thou hast founded
them.²

Thou makest the outgoings of the morning and
evening to rejoice.

Thou visitest the earth, and waterest it,
Thou greatly enrichest it;
The river of God is full of water:
Thou providest them corn, when thou hast so prepared
the earth.

Thou waterest her furrows abundantly;
Thou settest the ridges thereof:
Thou makest it soft with showers;
Thou blessest the springing thereof.
Thou crownest the year with thy goodness;
And thy paths drop fatness.
They drop upon the pastures of the wilderness:
And the hills are girded with joy.

The pastures are clothed with flocks;
The valleys also are covered over with corn;
They shout for joy, they also sing.³

The day is thine, the night also is thine:
Thou hast prepared the light and the sun.
Thou hast set all the borders of the earth:
Summer and winter, thou hast made them.⁴

While the earth remaineth, seedtime and harvest, and
cold and heat, and summer and winter, and day and
night shall not cease.⁵

¹Ps. 33: 6.
²Ps. 89: 11.

³Ps. 65: 8-13.
⁴Ps. 89: 16-17 (OA).

⁵Gen. 8: 22.

Yea, the stork in the heaven knoweth her appointed times; and the turtle and the swallow and the crane observe the time of their coming.¹

For he spake, and it was done;
He commanded, and it stood fast.²

Which have placed the sand for the bound of the sea, by a perpetual decree, that it cannot pass it; and though the waves thereof toss themselves, yet can they not prevail; though they roar, yet can they not pass over it.³

He stretcheth out the north over empty space,
And hangeth the earth upon nothing.⁴

He is wise in heart, and mighty in strength:
Who hath hardened himself against him, and prospered?

Which removeth the mountains, and they know it not,
When he overturneth them in his anger.
Which shaketh the earth out of her place,
And the pillars thereof tremble.
Which commandeth the sun, and it riseth not;
And sealeth up the stars.
Which alone stretcheth out the heavens,
And treadeth upon the waves of the sea.
Which maketh the Bear, Orion, and the Pleiades,
And the chambers of the south.

Which doeth great things past finding out;
Yea, marvellous things without number.⁵

In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. And the earth was waste and void; and darkness

¹Jer. 8: 7.
²Ps. 33: 9.

³Jer. 5: 22.
⁴Job 26: 7.

⁵Job 9: 4-10.

was upon the face of the deep: and the spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.¹

Bless the Lord, O my soul.

O Lord my God, thou art very great;
Thou art clothed with honour and majesty.
Who coverest thyself with light as with a garment;
Who stretchest out the heavens like a curtain:
Who layeth the beams of his chambers in the waters;
Who maketh the clouds his chariot;
Who walketh upon the wings of the wind:
Who maketh winds his messengers;
His ministers a flaming fire:
Who laid the foundations of the earth,
That it should not be moved for ever.

Thou coveredst it with the deep as with a vesture;
The waters stood above the mountains.
At thy rebuke they fled;
At the voice of thy thunder they hasted away;
They went up by the mountains, they went down by
the valleys,
Unto the place which thou hadst founded for them.
Thou hast set a bound that they may not pass over;
That they turn not again to cover the earth.

He sendeth forth springs into the valleys;
They run among the mountains:
They give drink to every beast of the field;
The wild asses quench their thirst.
By them the fowl of the heaven have their habitation,
They sing among the branches.
He watereth the mountains from his chambers:
The earth is satisfied with the fruit of thy works.

¹Gen. 1: 1.

He causeth the grass to grow for the cattle,
And herb for the service of man;
That he may bring forth food out of the earth:
And wine that maketh glad the heart of man,
And oil to make his face to shine,
And bread that strengtheneth man's heart.

The trees of the Lord are satisfied;
The cedars of Lebanon, which he hath planted;
Where the birds make their nests;
As for the stork, the fir trees are her house.
The high mountains are for the wild goats ;
The rocks are a refuge for the conies.

He appointed the moon for seasons:
The sun knoweth his going down.
Thou makest darkness, and it is night;
Wherein all the beasts of the forest do creep forth.
The young lions roar after their prey,
And seek their meat from God.
The sun ariseth, they get them away,
And lay them down in their dens.
Man goeth forth to his work
And to his labour until the evening.

O Lord, how manifold are thy works!
In wisdom hast thou made them all:
The earth is full of thy riches.
Yonder is the sea, great and wide,
Wherein are things creeping innumerable,
Both small and great beasts.
There go the ships;
There is leviathan, whom thou hast formed to take his
pastime therein.
These wait all upon thee,
That thou mayest give them their meat in due season.
That thou givest unto them they gather;
Thou openest thy hand, they are satisfied with good.

Thou hidest they face, they are troubled;
Thou takest away their breath, they die,
And return to their dust.

Thou sendest forth thy spirit, they are created;
And thou renewest the face of the ground.

Let the glory of the Lord endure for ever;
Let the Lord rejoice in his works:
Who looketh on the earth, and it trembleth;
He toucheth the mountains, and they smoke.

I will sing unto the Lord as long as I live:
I will sing my praise to my God while I have any being.
Let my meditation be sweet unto him:
I will rejoice in the Lord.
Let sinners be consumed out of the earth,
And let the wicked be no more.

Bless the Lord, O my soul.¹

And God saw everything that he had made, and,
behold, it was very good.²

Praise the Lord from the earth,
Ye sea-monsters, and all deeps:
Fire and hail, snow and vapour;
Stormy wind, fulfilling his word:
Mountains and all hills;
Fruitful trees and all cedars:
Beasts and all cattle;
Creeping things and flying fowl:

Kings of the earth and all peoples;
Princes and all judges of the earth:
Both young men and maidens;
Old men and children:
Let them praise the name of the Lord.³

¹Ps. 104.

²Gen. 1: 31.

³Ps. 148: 7-13 (M).

He hath made the earth by his power, he hath established the world by his wisdom.¹

But where shall wisdom be found?
And where is the place of understanding?²

The Lord formed me as the beginning of his way,
The first of his works of old.
I was set up from everlasting, from the beginning,
Or ever the earth was.
When there were no depths, I was brought forth;
When there were no fountains abounding with water.
Before the mountains were settled,
Before the hills was I brought forth;
While as yet he had not made the earth, nor the fields,
Nor the beginning of the dust of the world.
When he established the heavens, I was there:
When he set a circle upon the face of the deep:
When he made firm the skies above:
When the fountains of the deep became strong:
When he gave to the sea its bound,
That the waters should not transgress his commandment:
When he marked out the foundations of the earth:
Then I was by him, as a master workman:
And I was daily his delight,
Rejoicing always before him;
Rejoicing in his habitable earth;
And my delight was with the sons of men.³

Surely I am more brutish than any man,
And have not the understanding of a man:
And I have not learned wisdom,
Neither have I the knowledge of the Holy One.

¹Jer. 10: 12.

²Job 28: 12.

³Prov. 8: 22-31 (M).

Who hath ascended up into heaven, and descended?
Who hath gathered the wind in his fists?
Who hath bound the waters in his garment?
Who hath established all the ends of the earth?
What is his name, and what is his son's name, if
thou knowest?¹

Who is this that darkeneth counsel
By words without knowledge?
Gird up now thy loins like a man;
For I will demand of thee, and declare thou unto me.
Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the
earth?

Declare, if thou hast understanding.
Who determined the measures thereof, if thou knowest?
Or who stretched the line upon it?
Whereupon were the foundations thereof fastened?
Or who laid the corner stone thereof;
When the morning stars sang together,
And all the sons of God shouted for joy?

Or who shut up the sea with doors,
When it brake forth, as if it had issued out of the womb?
When I made the cloud the garment thereof,
And thick darkness a swaddlingband for it,
And prescribed for it my decree,
And set bars and doors,
And said, Hitherto shalt thou come, but no further;
And here shall thy proud waves be stayed?

Hast thou commanded the morning since thy days
began,
And caused the dayspring to know its place;
That it might take hold of the ends of the earth,
And the wicked be shaken out of it?

¹Prov. 30: 2-4.

It is changed as clay under the seal;
And all things stand forth as a garment:
And from the wicked their light is withholden,
And the high arm is broken.

Hast thou entered into the springs of the sea?
Or hast thou walked in the recesses of the deep?
Have the gates of death been revealed unto thee?
Or hast thou seen the gates of the shadow of death?
Hast thou comprehended the breadth of the earth?
Declare, if thou knowest it all.

Where is the way to the dwelling of light,
And as for darkness, where is the place thereof;
That thou shouldest take it to the bound thereof,
And that thou shouldst discern the paths to the house
thereof?

Doubtless, thou knowest, for thou wast then born,
And the number of thy days is great!

Hast thou entered the treasures of the snow,
Or hast thou seen the treasures of the hail,
Which I have reserved against the time of trouble,
Against the day of battle and war?
By what way is the light parted,
Or the east wind scattered upon the earth?
Who hath cleft a channel for the waterflood,
Or a way for the lightning of the thunder;
To cause it to rain on a land where no man is;
On the wilderness, wherein there is no man;
To satisfy the waste and desolate ground;
And to cause the tender grass to spring forth?

Hath the rain a father?
Or who hath begotten the drops of dew?
Out of whose womb came the ice?
And the hoary frost of heaven, who hath gendered it?
The waters are hidden as with stone,
And the face of the deep is frozen.

Canst thou bind the cluster of the Pleiades,
Or loose the bands of Orion?
Canst thou lead forth the Mazzaroth in their season?
Or canst thou guide the Bear with her train?
Knowest thou the ordinances of the heavens?
Canst thou establish the dominion thereof in the earth?
Canst thou lift up thy voice to the clouds,
That abundance of waters may cover thee?
Canst thou send forth lightnings, that they may go,
And say unto thee, Here we are?

Who hath put wisdom in the inward parts?
Or who hath given understanding to the mind?
Who can number the clouds by wisdom?
Or who can pour out the bottles of heaven,
When the dust runneth into a mass,
And the clods cleave fast together?

Wilt thou hunt the prey for the lioness?
Or satisfy the appetite of the young lions,
When they couch in their dens,
And abide in the covert to lie in wait?

Who provideth for the raven his food,
When his young ones cry unto God,
And wander for lack of meat?¹

He giveth to the beast his food,
And to the young ravens which cry.²

I am the Lord, and there is none else. I form the light,
and create darkness; I make peace, and create evil ;
I am the Lord, that doeth all these things.³

Except the Lord build the house,
They labour in vain that build it:
Except the Lord keep the city,
The watchman waketh but in vain.⁴

¹Job 38.

²Ps. 147: 9.

³Isa. 45: 6-7.

⁴Ps. 127: 1.

Hast thou not known? hast thou not heard? the everlasting God, the Lord, the Creator of the ends of the earth, fainteth not, neither is weary; there is no searching of his understanding. He giveth power to the faint; and to him that hath no might he increaseth strength.¹

Which made heaven and earth,
The sea, and all that in them is;
Which keepeth truth for ever;
Which executeth judgement for the oppressed;
Which giveth food to the hungry:
The Lord looseth the prisoners;
The Lord openeth the eyes of the blind;
The Lord raiseth up them that are bowed down;
The Lord loveth the righteous;
The Lord preserveth the strangers;
He upholdeth the fatherless and widow.²

Know ye that the Lord he is God:
It is he that hath made us, and we are his.³

Forsake not the works of thine own hands.⁴

¹Isa. 40: 28-29.

²Ps. 146: 6-9.

³Ps. 100: 3.

⁴Ps. 138: 8.